

IPCop 2.0.6: The New Watchdog!

This article describes the various functionalities of a network-based firewall, besides taking readers through the installation and configuration of IPCop 2.0.6, especially from the perspective of a small and medium business. It also illustrates how a securely configured firewall ensures data security and mitigates various risks such as virus spread.



IPCop is a complete Linux distribution whose sole purpose is to protect the networks it is installed on. By implementing the best of current technology, outstanding new technology and secure programming practices, it has become *the* Linux distro for those wanting to keep their computers and networks safe.

Basics

There are two types of firewalls.

Host-based firewalls are typically software programs installed on an operating system. They can control which software programs installed on the computer can access the Internet and who can access the host system.

Network firewalls are used to control access between any two networks—for example, your system or network on one side, and the Internet on the other. Any computer system or network directly connected to the Internet without

any protection is exposed to many risks. From a security perspective, once you are connected to the Internet, it is your computer, your system and your network against everybody else on the other side. Even unknowingly, other infected systems could cause harm to your system. A firewall is used to mitigate these risks and to secure your internal systems from malicious users and programs working on the external side.

Network security for small businesses

Though awareness about firewalls is on the rise, even today, many organisations assume that installing the operating system, application software and the connecting network is all that's required to set up their IT infrastructure. Many key network security aspects such as the use of managed switches, securing the wireless network, changing default passwords, deploying a firewall at the network gateway, etc, are not considered.